Nocturnal Rites – Archive, Memory and Euphoria

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Introduction: beginning with loss

When I dismantled the exhibition, something unexpected happened. It felt like a kind of loss, as if something alive was being removed. The room was emptied. The sound disappeared. The projections went dark. What had existed there could not be returned to in the same form. It was like a funeral. A time had ended. The party was over.

The images themselves live on, but not in the same form, and not in the same time in which I showed them. What remained was the memory of a state, and the feeling that something was gone for good.

There is a strange contradiction in this. Photography and video, the media most commonly understood as capable of preserving moments, are also the ones that remind us of what we have lost. Roland Barthes explores this in *Camera Lucida: Reflections on Photography* (La Chambre claire, 1980)[1]. For Barthes, every photo shows that something once existed, but also reminds us that the moment is gone and can't be reached again.

He uses the idea of the *punctum* to describe a detail in a photo that touches the viewer deeply, a personal, often painful feeling that can't be explained, only felt. The photograph functions not only as documentation but as an affective object: it evokes a feeling of presence precisely because it points toward absence. There is a built-in melancholy in every image.

Taking the exhibition down became an embodied reflection on this. What had been alive in the room was cremated into memory. And it was at that exact moment that the project's central themes came into focus for me: archive, memory, euphoria, ritual and loss. These are not separate categories. They are part of the same experience, connected in one flow. It starts with being present, moves to loss, and never really ends.

This text is an attempt to understand how these concepts move through the work. Not by defining them once and for all, but by tracing them: from recording to editing, from installation to dissolution. I want to do more than explain what the work is. I want to understand what it does, to me, to the material, and to those who encounter it.

[1] Barthes, R., 1980. *Camera Lucida: Reflections on Photography*. Translated by R. Howard. New York: Hill and Wang.

Participating rather than observing

To create something that feels close, I must have been a part of it. Observing from a distance is not enough. I must have lived inside the situation, otherwise the work lacks weight, the kind of presence that cannot be simulated or constructed.

Observation means separation. It draws a clear line between subject and object, between the one who sees and the thing that is seen. The camera, in that position, becomes an instrument of obsession, categorisation and reduction, a tool for capturing something from the outside. That is not the position I am looking for. I do not want to stand apart and analyse people.

To participate means something different: to be part of what is happening, to be affected by it, to not be in full control. It means allowing yourself to be shaped by the situation rather than simply framing it. It requires a careful kind of attention, not an exploitative one. And the hardest part of that work is not the documenting. It is returning to the material in the editing room, months or years later, and trying to reconstruct not just what happened but how it felt, the atmosphere, the energy, the specific quality of a moment that the camera didn't fully capture.

This kind of gaze demands a different attitude, one that accepts uncertainty and unpredictability, that does not try to capture the whole truth but instead shares an experience. You have to be ready to catch the accidental, to let the unexpected shape the material. But this position has its own contradictions. Even when you take part, the camera is still present. Recording always means making choices. What you choose to film, and what you choose not to, is never objective. It is in precisely this tension between participation and control that the work takes shape.

The aim is to show, not to explain. Image and sound should carry the experience on their own. In documentary filmmaking the goal is to show reality, not how it is, but how it feels [2]. By positioning yourself inside other people's lives, you can find simultaneous reflections on your own.

The archive as construction

My master's project *Nocturnal Rites* draws from a personal archive of moving images, material I filmed over several years in Barcelona between 2015 and 2018, documenting everything from social conflicts to social gatherings, using a DV camera. A camera with its own particular limitations. Its technical imperfection was not an obstacle but an expression. I received it when I was thirteen and began building a private archive early on, driven to digitise every tape and create a collection to preserve for the future.

An archive is often understood as an objective collection of the past, something that preserves what has been. But in practice, an archive is always selective. It is a construction, a set of choices, a way of remembering, and also a way of forgetting. The archive is not just memory; it is a system that produces memory. It determines what can be recalled and what disappears, what counts and what is excluded. Whoever creates the archive sets the conditions for what can be remembered. The power within the archive is not abstract, it is practical and concrete: a single cut in the editing room can determine whether a person exists in the story at all.

What does it mean to represent specific people and specific situations? I believe emotions are key. I want to create experiences that make people feel and recognize something, even if they've never been in the places I show.

[2] Bok, Bengt. *Den dokumentära dramaturgin: Anteckningar från ett sökande*. Carlsson Bokförlag, 2013.

The installation

The work is a video installation in an immersive room, like a black box with red velvet and black curtains. A custom screen and a projection surround the viewer, making the work a physical experience. To enter the space, visitors must pass through what looks like a nightclub entrance, complete with a red carpet and brass pillars. Sound pulses through a six-channel audio system. The entire room is designed to evoke the sensation of crossing over, of stepping into a different state, of leaving behind the logic of everyday life.

The work follows a dramaturgy similar to the structure of a night out, divided into four phases: Arrival, Build-up, Peak and Dissolution. The video shows nights out in Barcelona, ritualistic and intense movement, characters who appear and vanish, moments of collective ecstasy. It is not a work about a nightclub as a place. It is a work about the state that the night makes possible.

The red carpet functions both as an invitation and a barrier. It reflects how clubs operate: inclusive and exclusive at the same time. During the opening night I hired an actor to play a doorman outside. A queueing system was formed, offering a comic but thought-provoking image, observation met participation.

The original intention was for the audience to want to dance, to feel drawn into the energy the work carries. But as the process developed, something shifted. I realised the work was not really an invitation to join an ongoing party. It was something closer to a memorial, a collection of wonderful nights condensed into a single room, preserved just because they could not be repeated. The energy was still there, but it was the energy of memory rather than of presence. Something to remember, rather than something to enter.



Entering the exhibition, *Nocturnal Rites*, 2026

The camera as participant

One particular club, “GLOVE PARTY,” with queer undertones, became a central meeting place during those years. It functioned as a gathering point for a network of people who knew each other. The music and dancing created an intense feeling of community and euphoria, and the camera often circulated among us. I passed it around and appeared in the material myself. The camera was not an instrument. It was an object in motion, moving through the hands of the social group.

This fundamentally changed the relationship between camera and subject. The camera was no longer directed at an object from outside, it moved within the community, between bodies, hands and perspectives.

Using a nostalgic DV camera, one that many people associate with family holidays in the early 2000s, made it disarming. What might otherwise be perceived as a documentation tool was experienced by many who saw it as an invitation. Instead of turning away, they wanted to look straight into the lens. They wanted to be seen.



Logotype of Glove Party, the nightclub

Fragments and living memories

There is something particular about these video fragments. They do not function as whole stories but as intense concentrations of experience, remains of something that no longer exists, but that can still be felt. Still alive in the body. They do not require context to work. They appear as small, powerful moments: a laugh, a glance, a hand on a shoulder, light breaking through smoke. The larger thing, the euphoria, the community, the night as a state of being, appears in the details.

Memory does not simply replay the past in order. It is a changing and complex process, where the past is rebuilt each time we remember it. Memory is made of fragments, some images, feelings, and events stay, while others fade or disappear. Every time we recall a memory, it is shaped by the situation, by new experiences, and by how we understand it now. Memory is not like a storage box. It is a process.

Walter Benjamin captures this in “A Berlin Chronicle” (*Berliner Chronik*, 1932): memory is not an instrument for exploring the past, but its theatre [3]. Rather than treating memory as a tool that can objectively reproduce the past, Benjamin argues that it functions as a stage

[3] Benjamin, W. 1978. 'A Berlin Chronicle', in *Reflections: Essays, Aphorisms, Autobiographical Writings*.

on which the past is constantly replayed, shaped by feelings, interpretations and the situation we find ourselves in when we remember. Each time we return to a memory, it is made again. In *Berliner Kindheit um neunzehnhundert* [4] Benjamin applies this very method: instead of a traditional autobiography, he creates short memory images and impressions from his childhood in Berlin. The past surfaces in fragments, without chronological order. Memory as theatre, not as archive.

The power and ethics of editing

The video work is structured as though the night never ends. I wanted to test the idea of holding onto a feeling, to show love as a state rather than an event. To show people in their best moments, but also in their most exhausted.

Working with the material now, years later, another dimension appears. Many of the people involved have probably forgotten they were filmed. But the images remain. I sit in the editing room and find myself constantly inside a party that no longer exists. It creates a strange feeling of power, and with that power, an ethical responsibility.

In the edit, I am almighty over the material. I can decide when the party begins and when it ends. I can cut together different evenings into a single night, intensify certain encounters and remove others, add sound, change the rhythm and manipulate the passage of time. I can shape how these people come across, how the night is remembered and who is visible. That position is not neutral.

It carries an ethical dimension I cannot avoid. What does it mean that other people continue to exist in my archive while they themselves have moved on with their lives? The archive here is not only a place for memory but also a place for control. And the further I work into the material, the clearer it becomes that I can never return to what happened. I can only work with its remains.

The story is, fundamentally, a fabrication, a manipulation of reality. That should not be understood as something negative. Manipulation is present in every artistic process. All film is an artificial construction. What matters is the awareness of that construction, and the ethical responsibility with which you approach it. Editing is the art of taking what seems like the random chaos of events and giving it structure, not by following rules, but through method and ethical consciousness [5].

Image and perception: an awakening

I am rooted in a particular way of seeing images, shaped by norms and self-imposed rules that I had long left unquestioned. It was after encountering Pipilotti Rist's installation *Gravity, Be My Friend* [6] that my ideas about what video is allowed to be were turned upside down.

The work is projected onto the ceiling, and visitors lie down on soft platforms to look up. I fell into a trance-like state. Rist works with multiple layers of image material: close-ups of skin, fruit and nature blended with abstract colour fields and digital manipulation. The result is not a traditional narrative but a flow of visual fragments that resemble memory images. The effects are essentially simple, layers drifting over each other, soft transitions, slow motion, chroma key, but the outcome is a strange visual dance in which bodies, plants and colours slowly dissolve into each other.

There is something disarming in her way of working: an unpretentious grace in which images move slowly and with a genuine generosity. The imperfect, the unpolished, the things that are not quite right, all of it is given space, creating a kind of humour and warmth that the technically perfect image can never achieve. Imperfection is what makes it feel real.

I later incorporated many of her techniques into my own editing work. The real lesson wasn't about a specific tool, but about a change in approach: working intuitively, following feeling instead of control. The nights I filmed weren't arranged or planned, they were messy, dark, overexposed, with motion blur and bad sound. I also chose to show people who, each night, revealed their true selves: honest, showing warmth. The DV footage from Barcelona, with all its grain and instability, was not a failed attempt at documentation. It was already, in its own way, a way of describing an honest feeling.

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[4] Benjamin, W. *Berliner Kindheit um Neunzehnhundert*. Frankfurt am Main: Suhrkamp, 1985.

[5] Bok, Bengt. *Den dokumentära dramaturgin: Anteckningar från ett sökande*. Carlsson Bokförlag, 2013.

[6] Rist, P., 2007. *Gravity, Be My Friend*. [Video installation] Exhibited at Accelerator, Stockholm (2025).



Pipilotti Rist, 'Gravity, Be My Friend', 2007. Photo: Jean-Baptiste Béranger

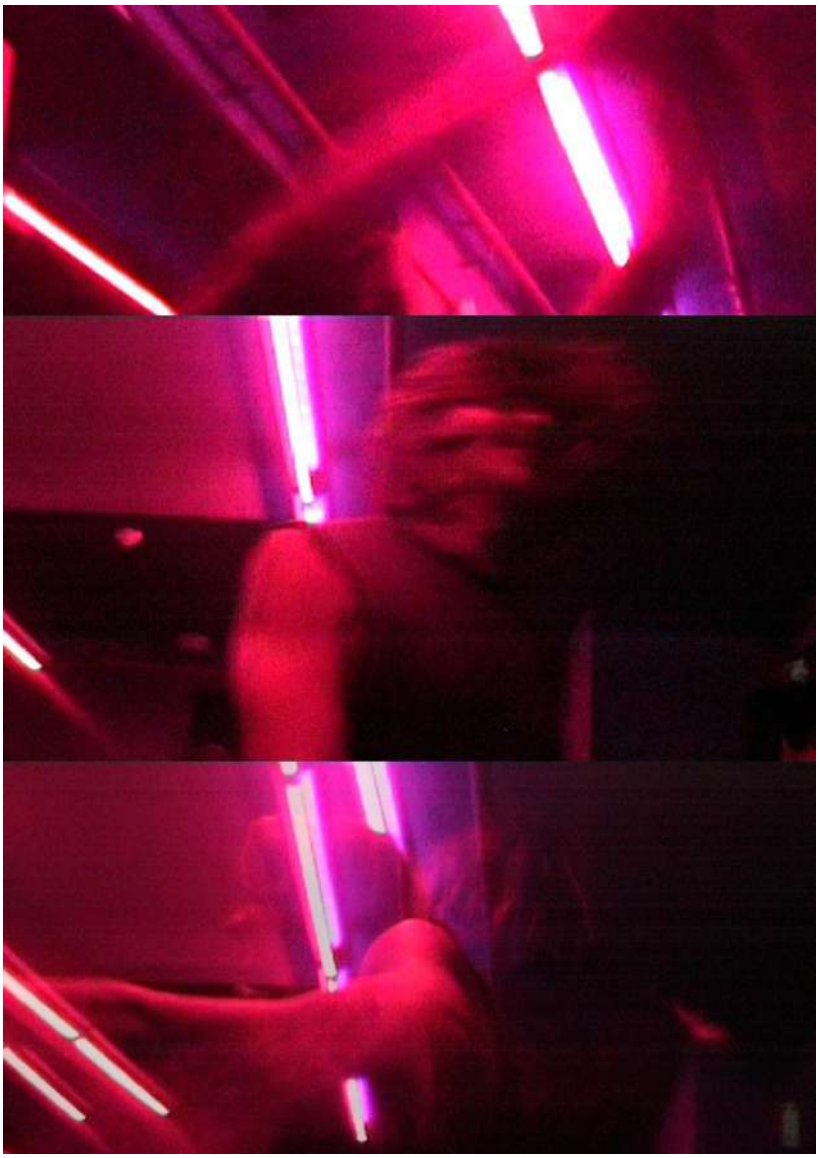
Sound, rhythm and perception

Early in the editing process I identified a climax in the video that I wanted to build toward. In that scene, a person named José dances repeatedly, disappearing into his own movement, almost in a trance, with a violet light in the background. The scene worked perfectly with the track "Faces" by Clio[7], It captures the essence of Italo-disco: a simple but driving drum machine, soft analogue synthesisers, and a melancholic vocal that feels almost weightless. The track is danceable, both euphoric and melancholic in equal measure.

In the film I let the track return and continue its peak. By holding it on repeat and letting the climax build and then return in two separate parts of the film, it comes to function almost like a signal. Each time it recurs, it feels like stepping into something again. The dancing body moves in violet light, over and over, and the music gradually draws José deeper into the movement. I also used a tool called Paulstretch [8], which can stretch a sound until it becomes almost unrecognisable. A fast pop song can begin to sound like an angelic field of frequencies. I tried to create the same effect in the whole installation, where the line between reality and dream starts to fade. Sound isn't just something we hear, it's something we feel. While working on the video piece, I listened repeatedly, without stopping, to an archived SoundCloud playlist, music that had been played at the disco parties I was portraying. Over time, it helped me reconnect with that atmosphere, to the point where I felt almost stuck in it, caught in that time as I worked, finding the right rhythm and mood.

[7] Clio, 1985. "Faces." On *Faces*. Ariola.

[8] Paul, N.O. 2006. *Paulstretch* [Software].



A dancing José, excerpt from my video work

The night as ritual

The night makes possible a different way of being. During the day we are disciplined, operating within the structures of ordinary life. At night, something shifts. Other versions of us come forward. Norms become more flexible, identities more open. There is a permission in the darkness that does not exist in daylight, a freedom that does not need to be justified, only lived.

Some nights become more than entertainment. They can take on a ritual quality, a kind of contemporary ceremony where people step into a different state. Certain nights create a sense of community and, occasionally, even resistance, a temporary utopia can emerge through shared dance. For a while, you can belong to each other without having to explain why.

In *The Birth of Tragedy*[9], Friedrich Nietzsche describes the Dionysian state as one where personal feelings disappear, the self vanishes, and you are absorbed into a sense of oneness. It isn't something you choose, it is a state that overwhelms you. The body stops being just your own and becomes part of the collective rhythm. In that state you are no longer alone. You are part of something larger.

Georges Bataille adds a deeper and more complicated layer. In *L'Expérience intérieure* (*Inner Experience*, 1943) [10], he describes ecstasy as a borderland state in which anxiety and ecstasy do not just coexist but merge. It is an experience that forces the self to dissolve; the old self must, as he puts it, "die" to make room for something new, a form of rebirth. Bataille emphasises that this is not a peaceful process. It is violent, intense and fundamentally necessary. Ecstasy means letting go completely, a feeling of limitless freedom where a person faces their own vulnerability and catches a glimpse of something infinite. It is an existential experience that both frightens and

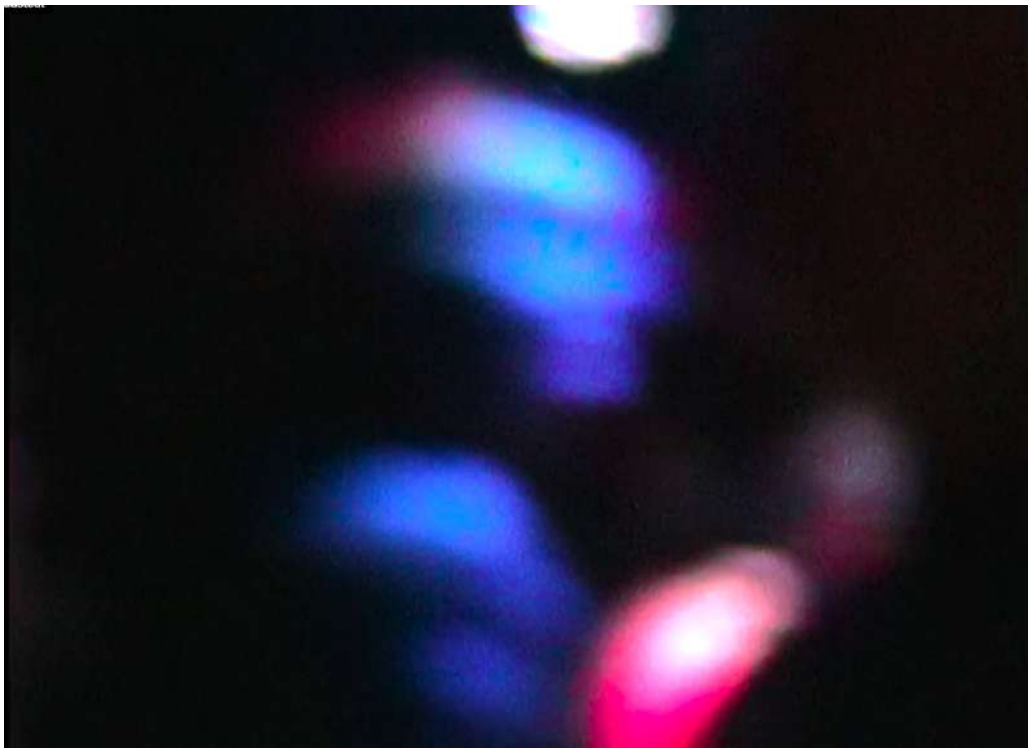
[9] Nietzsche, F., 1872. *The Birth of Tragedy out of the Spirit of Music*. Translated by S. Whiteside. London: Penguin, 1993.
[10] Bataille, G., 1943. *Inner Experience*. Translated by L.A. Boldt. Albany: State University of New York Press, 1988.

liberates, challenging every conventional idea of morality, order and safety.

The euphoria at its best is intense but also unstable. Ecstasy implies a dissolution of the self, a liberation, but also a risk. Boundaries blur: between self and others, between body and space. It is intense but fragile. Each repetition changes the experience. What was once euphoric risks becoming something you try to recapture, rather than something you simply live inside.

Generative transformation

One of the central qualities of my recorded material is the way the image changes when it encounters the night. Darkness, rapid movement, and the technical limitations of the camera gradually cause the image to break down. Faces begin to resemble textures, while bodies fragment into colour and motion. In some sequences, the interior of a club becomes a collage of darkness and flashes of light, and people appear as brief, bright images.



Still from video work, (human-light shaped)

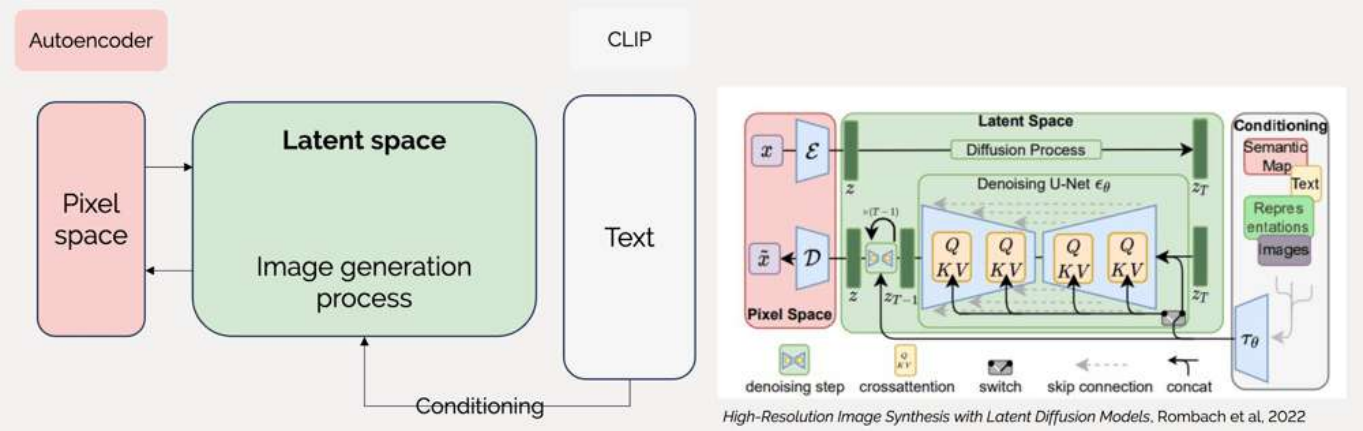
In my video work, I wanted each ending to combine fragments of the song “Faces” with a feeling of total euphoria. To express this, I began distorting the images, using animation to create a stage of complete visual dissolution. To explore this transformation even further, I experimented with generative image models. Although often broadly described as AI, I trained my own model using recordings from my archive. I was interested in a process that could generate new visual material while remaining connected to the original footage. For this purpose, I trained a model using Low-Rank Adaptation (LoRA), a technique that allows an existing model to learn new visual characteristics without retraining the entire system. The model was built within Stable Diffusion, an open-source generative image software. Diffusion models create images through a process that begins with random visual noise. From this chaotic starting point, the system gradually transforms the noise into a recognisable image. Because the starting point changes each time, the model does not reproduce the exact images it was trained on. Instead, it generates new images shaped by the training material, yet never identical to it. This randomness is an essential aspect of the work.

The intention is not to produce perfect or stable images, nor to recreate the original footage. Instead, the system functions as a tool for experimentation. The generated images were then used as textures within my animations. They zoom, rotate, and slowly transform

over time. Colours shift, shapes merge and dissolve, and figures sometimes appear only briefly before disappearing again. Working like this helped me build on the qualities that were already in the original recordings. The camera had already begun transforming the nightclub scenes into textures and fragments. The generative process continues this transformation, producing new images that still carry traces of the original material while moving further away from clear representation.



Texture from the animated stills



Overview of the stable diffusion structure

Nostalgia

When I began to digitise the DV tapes, the nostalgia arrived almost immediately. After the first minute it was already clear that what I was watching was already lost. The archive was not a place of preservation. It became a place where loss was made visible, where absence was given a face.

What is nostalgia, really? Is it loss? Is it happiness? A wish to recreate, to bring something back? I think it is the life we once lived that we want to return to. But perhaps what we long for is not what actually happened, but the feeling memory has given it, the past as a theatre piece, rewritten by the present.

Two months after the exhibition I noticed that the nostalgia had become almost too much. I felt genuinely unwilling to return to the images, as though it had been enough. It was difficult to pick up again; as if I first needed to want something new before I could move forward. Nostalgia carries an artistic risk: getting stuck in what was, letting longing for the past replace movement forward.
The club I portray also contains its own performance of nostalgia, a tribute to another era, expressed in the choice of disco music and the way people dressed. A longing not to belong to contemporary society, a kind of escape from a present that feels increasingly alienating. The DV camera with its aesthetic is itself an artefact of nostalgia, a reaching back not just toward a place but toward a time.

What remains

In the end, Nocturnal Rites is about movement, community, and loss. It's about dancing with others, about dissolving into a collective rhythm and then returning: to solitude, to memory. Euphoria cannot be held; it can only be recalled in fragments. What remains is not the image itself, but the sensation it leaves behind in the body. I hope that when these materials leave my archive and encounter a stranger, they no longer belong only to my memory. The images carry the possibility of recognition in someone else, a night they lived, or one they never did but somehow still feel. In that instant, the archive stops being just a record and becomes alive: not just a document of the past, but an opening into another person's present. The party ends, yet the feeling remains. And each time the video plays, it begins again.

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